STRATEGY / DOCUMENT S01 / EVIDENCE-LED INVESTMENT THESIS

PSS Acceptance 360
Strategic Investment Case

A conditional bank-infrastructure growth thesis, comparative options and the evidence required before any capital commitment

Prepared from the perspective of Research, Product & Business Development Division

19 October 2026 • Version 1.0 • Confidential personal research / prospective management discussion

CONTROL FIELD	VALUE
Document ID	PSS-A360-S01-001; controlled strategic paper in the proposed Acceptance 360 programme
Standing	Pre-appointment, public-source research draft; not an official PSS position, feasibility result, business plan or investment authorisation
Intended audience	Prospective PSS division / CFO / Technology / Risk / Legal management reviewers and, following authorisation, Executive Committee
Source cut-off	19 October 2026; public external sources and existing PSS A360 draft work products
Decision question	Should PSS authorise a bounded study of bank-sponsored merchant operations + connectivity, keeping full scale and live pilots out of scope?
Author / accountable owner	Prepared from proposed Research, Product & Business Development leadership perspective; owner to be formally appointed
Reviewers needed	Chief Financial Officer; Technology & Operations; Legal/Compliance; CISO/Risk; Commercial / relevant bank sponsor (all pending)
Priority dependencies	S02 options; S03 current-state; V02 market; V03 bank protocol; V04 merchant protocol; V05 existing-product pre-access framework

Executive investment proposition

Proposed direction: Validate a narrowly scoped PSS Operate + Connect service: a bank-sponsored merchant-payment operations and reusable connectivity proposition. Keep PSS Pay expansion as a fully viable counter-option. **Do not approve a new national merchant-agent platform, unconditional product build, or revenue forecast yet.**

The thesis is that banks may pay for a demonstrable reduction in merchant-payment reconciliation, exception resolution and multi-channel servicing costs. PSS has public evidence of longstanding payments assets and recently announced merchant-facing capabilities, but actual reuse rights, product maturity, costs, licences and demand remain unverified [S03; P02-P05].

Decision stage: the next request is permission to validate a business hypothesis. No PSS, member-bank, merchant or supplier data have been accessed for this S01 paper. No executive approval or bank sponsorship exists in this package.

Executive decision summary

QUESTION	CURRENT POSITION	CONCLUSION / ACTION
Strategic fit	PSS switching, POS-related and security businesses create adjacency; newer services are publicly announced.	Plausible strategic fit, not operational proof. Validate assets, scope and ownership [P02-P04].
Market	Low historical physical POS coverage, large wallet merchant footprints and merchant use of personal accounts coexist.	Study merchant service/operating gaps, not merely the number of merchants without POS [P01, P06-P08].
Bank economic buyer	Bank pain, procurement authority, willing price and baseline alternatives not evidenced.	Hard commercial gate: qualifying bank problem and actual willingness to buy [V03].
Product proof	Merchant research and performance audits have not been executed.	Require PSS Pay cohorts and merchant workflows; compare with existing services [V04, V05].
Financial result	No current validated revenues, bank prices, integration CAPEX or direct costs.	No current NPV/IRR or investment verdict; finance must model both sides under downside [F05].
Regulation/security	New permissions reported; original documents and exact scheme and PCI scopes uninspected.	Mandatory Legal, Compliance, acquirer, scheme and CISO clearance prior to live testing [P02, P03, P09, P10].

Management vote at this stage: Support a capped and approved research programme only. Reserve the right to select PSS Pay-led, partner-led or no-build after credible evidence.

1 Investment thesis and what it is not

PSS Acceptance 360 is a proposed umbrella for merchant-acceptance services. It must not be treated as an existing legal entity, licensed product suite, production deployment or approved PSS strategy. A financeable entry product would sell a bank measurable operational improvement rather than a broad national inclusion promise.

RETAIN FROM ORIGINAL CONCEPT	CHANGE FOR THIS INVESTMENT CASE	DEFER OR EXCLUDE
Interoperability; consumer safeguards; disciplined exception evidence; inclusion outcome.	Start with contracted bank problem, bounded service modules and measurable cost/quality improvement.	Own nationwide agent network, speculative subsidy entitlement and broad multi-rail build.
Existing PSS switching/merchant infrastructure as possible reuse inputs.	Test incremental reuse and integration rights before designing a replacement core.	Assume PSS Secure/3DS confers SoftPOS, QR or general merchant approval.
Four independent post-research decision gates.	Add buyer economics and CFO gate before any product scope freeze.	Treat merchant registrations or option scores as automatic release triggers.

2 Evidence: why the opportunity is real but not yet PSS-specific

PUBLIC INDICATOR	WHAT IT SUPPORTS	WHAT IT DOES NOT PROVE
NBE draft NDPS: 14,030 POS terminals in June 2024 for about 2m MSMEs; 0.16% merchant-payment share of digital value in FY2023/24 [P01].	Historical physical terminal under-penetration and national merchant adoption policy need.	2026 live POS count; untapped merchant population; PSS bank willingness to pay.
MPO Ethiopia Wave 1, Apr 2026: 2,724 surveyed micro-enterprise merchants; 58.8% digital acceptance, 26% rural, >99% flows into personal accounts [P07].	Payments exist without mature formal merchant acquisition and services; segment and denominator caution.	PSS target TAM or exact banking-account conversion demand.
Ethio telecom FY2025/26: 440,100 telebirr merchants, 410,700 agents; integrated with 33 banks (operator-reported) [P06].	Installed competing footprint and importance of wallet/account links.	Unique active merchants; bank-specific PSS acceptance market.
EthSwitch FY2025/26: 387m interoperable transactions, 551.5k EthQR payments (operator-reported) [P05].	Large national interoperable rails and emerging QR.	PSS addressable payments, fee entitlement or merchant usage frequency.
NBE website labels NDPS 2026-2030 as draft [P01].	Directional policy interest in interoperable acceptance.	Funding, tariffs or legal changes already effective.

Interpretation: Potential value lies in bank-facing merchant service coordination across existing payment routes, but banks may already have acceptable solutions. Market opportunity and commercial opportunity are different hypotheses.

3 PSS-specific strategic logic: adjacency, not entitlement

REPORTED / PUBLIC ASSET	TESTABLE ADVANTAGE	CRITICAL VERIFICATION
Licensed switch operation: NBE register PSO/001/2013 [P02].	Institutional integration knowledge; potential bank interfaces.	Actual interfaces, contracts, service rights, capacity, SLA and marginal costs [S03].
POS infrastructure and terminal supply [P04].	Existing acceptance support and merchant servicing exposure.	Real installed base, service model, hardware contracts, inventory, acceptance economics.
2026 reported POS and gateway permissions; SoftPOS launch [P03].	Potential direct merchant-acceptance module.	Original grants, conditions, live version, settlement/acquirer contracts and performance.
PSS Secure EMV 3DS ACS [P11].	Separate card-not-present security offering and institutional client relationships.	Current client deployments, contracts, certification/renewal and product separation.
PSS Trading technology arm, company-reported [P03, P04].	Possible supply and delivery pathway.	Independent procurement, transfer pricing, related-party governance, IP and SLAs.

The S03 pre-access capability assessment maps 26 capability areas and 22 gaps. It does not verify actual PSS technical control, certification, costs or bank data. Use S03 as the audit specification, not a positive due-diligence opinion.

4 The proposed service: scope and customer promise

SERVICE LAYER	PROPOSED FUNCTION	RELEASE RULE
Operate — core	Transaction status and audit trace; exceptions; reconciliation and reversals support; bank dashboards; incident workflow; merchant service indicators.	First to validate with real bank reconciliation logs, cost and permission evidence; do not claim existing implementation.
Connect — core	Reusable bank integrations, adapters and permitted event/API routing into pre-existing national/card/wallet rails.	Only where rights, scheme participation, bank data segregation and technical feasibility are proven.
Accept — selectable	PSS Pay/SoftPOS and other approved POS or merchant channels configured to a sponsor bank.	Add only where current certifications, device compatibility and positive unit economics are established.
Grow — optional	Reporting and non-credit business services banks demonstrably purchase.	Later; avoid new credit, merchant profiling or consent assumptions.
Agent/shared network — out	No new exclusive or PSS-owned nationwide agent cash network in initial scope.	Reconsider only after national shared-network legal/business clarity.

5 Operating and settlement boundaries

The proposed arrangement is an infrastructure and contracted service relationship; it is not an assumption that PSS may hold deposits, operate a national payment scheme, execute KYC, approve credit or settle merchant funds. Actual regulatory duties must be allocated according to licences, laws, contracts and scheme rules—not broad conceptual role labels.

CONTROL ACTIVITY	BANK / LICENSED INSTITUTION	PSS RESPONSIBILITY TO VERIFY	OTHER
Onboard and assess merchants	Applicable KYC/account/acquiring obligations.	Permitted technical capture and workflow; access rights.	Identity providers only if authorised.
Transaction/settlement decisions	Bank, issuer/acquirer or applicable licensee according to rules.	Record outcomes, reconcile, route permitted messages.	Scheme/switch settlement system.
Processing and cyber risk	Bank duties remain.	PSS independent duties, controls, data protection and outsourcing oversight.	PCI-listed solution vendor where required.
Complaints and reversals	Decision authority and consumer liability per agreement/law.	Evidence, status, escalation and reporting services.	Network and merchant participant.

Never infer current SoftPOS certification from a historic PCI DSS Level 1 announcement. A publicly stated PSS 2025 PCI DSS certification ended 8 July 2026; verify current attestation and exact solution listing/scheme approvals [P10, P09].

6 Strategic alternatives: protect the decision

OPTION	INVESTMENT LOGIC	CURRENT STANCE	DISCONFIRMING FINDING
A Full Acceptance 360 now	Wide portfolio and multiple banks/channels from inception.	Do not build upfront. High coordination and unproven payer risk.	No bank coalition, no repeatable integration, high fixed cost.
B Operate + Connect	Bank pays for service cost reduction and repeatable integration.	Lead hypothesis for targeted validation.	Banks already solve exceptions economically or will not pay.
C PSS Pay-led	Reuse current card-on-phone acceptance investment.	Equal live alternative subject to performance evidence.	Poor device fit, scheme scope or negative unit contribution.
D Partner-led service	Use third-party tech plus PSS bank orchestration.	Require comparative supplier bid and commercial rights.	TCO, lock-in or compliance burden exceeds internal route.
E No new platform	Optimise BAU and preserve capital.	Explicit capital-protection baseline.	Opportunity cost demonstrably larger than controlled investment.

S02's prior internal judgemental scorecard provisionally ranked B 3.50/5, C 3.30/5, E 2.95/5, D 2.80/5 and A 2.15/5. These are not empirical readiness ratings and must not be used as a financial value, probability or board approval criterion. Under a risk-protection weighting, E rose above the build alternatives [S02].

6.1 Conditions that would change my recommendation

- Select C if an existing PSS Pay bank use case yields CFO-verified positive contribution, valid live permissions and stronger buyer commitments than B.
- Select D if independently priced partnership TCO, rights and data safeguards beat in-house development without strategic lock-in.
- Select E if V03 bank buyers reject recurring economics, S03 integration is unrepeatable, or downside F05 fails PSS investment limits.
- Consider expanding toward A only after multiple banks prove common service demand, bank adapters are repeatable and real operations pass live controls.

7 Customer jobs, contract design and market entry

BUYER / USER	PROPOSED JOB TO BE DONE	EVIDENCE STILL NEEDED
Acquiring bank COO / Head of Payments	Reduce reconciliation backlog, support effort, failed outcomes and fragmented merchant service tooling.	Baseline effort, exception rate, cost per item, procurement owner and expected savings.
Bank technology owner	Reduce repeated project/maintenance cost for approved acceptance integrations.	Real interfaces, technical constraints, reusable code and vendor dependency cost.
Bank commercial owner	Improve profitable merchant activity and merchant retention.	Merchant cohorts, pricing and net incremental fee margin; cannibalisation effects.
Merchant (end user)	Receive reliable confirmation, easier reconciliation, support and appropriate channel access.	Observed merchant workflow, willingness to use and switching/friction effects [V04].

The initial customer must be the bank economic buyer with the authority to sign or fund an offer. Merchant feedback helps product design; it is not substitute evidence of a bank purchase decision. V03 proposes 4–6 exploratory bank buyer interviews, while V04 proposes 36 qualitative merchant interviews; neither study has yet been executed.

8 Commercial model and two-sided value creation

PROPOSED BANK CONTRACT COMPONENT	COMMERCIAL PURPOSE	VALIDATION / RISK
One-time integration fee	Recover evidenced bank-specific engineering and acceptance costs.	Requires signed scope, acceptance conditions and separately tracked setup cost.
Monthly minimum managed-service fee	Cover standby, platform operations and SLA obligations.	Requires bank price acceptance; do not invent mandatory fees.
Active merchant / operational service fee	Align servicing price to real supported activity.	Precisely define active merchant and avoid double counting.
Permissible transaction-based fee	Charge for agreed approved processing functions.	Must align with current permissions, tariffs and rail arrangements.
Optional premium features	Bank reporting or support tiers with demonstrated benefit.	No merchant-data monetisation or credit assumptions without rights.

Bank value test: verified bank operating-cost reduction + incremental risk-adjusted bank margin − PSS charges − bank-side change costs > 0.

PSS value test: contracted revenue − bank-specific integration costs − processing/vendor/service/compliance costs − incremental overhead > investment hurdle.

These are decision formulas, not calculated investment returns. PSS fees, bank margins, costs, tax, funding and discount-rate inputs have not been verified. Exclude unapproved merchant discount rates, subsidies, QR interchange and future credit revenue from the base case.

9 Market sizing: from public context to verifiable sales pipeline

Do not multiply registered merchants, historical POS gaps or national interoperable transaction totals by hypothetical PSS fees. Estimate serviceable contracted revenue from bottom-up bank contracts: eligible bank buyers × validated likelihood of winning × signed/credible minimum recurring fees plus priced scope and permitted transaction revenue. Apply realistic sales lag, integration bottlenecks, attrition and concurrency limitations.

FUNNEL STAGE	REQUIRED INPUT	QUALITY RULE
Candidate banks	Bank list, segment and current acquiring activity.	Public sourcing can identify candidates; count no revenue.
Qualified addressable banks	Buyer interviews and bank workflow gap.	Document economic buyer, budget cycle and alternatives.
Commercially credible pipeline	Terms with dated scope, estimated price and decision path.	Treat LOI separately from enforceable contract.
Contracted / deployable	Signed agreement plus cleared implementation rights.	Only here does recurring contractual value enter committed case.
Active operating cohorts	Bank/merchant activity, support and transaction records.	Cost and revenue must follow actual activity and SLA obligations.

10 Investment feasibility work required before any build

S01 is not the comprehensive feasibility study. F01/F05 must model the selected narrow scope and all live comparator options. The old last-mile scenario workbook illustrated downside and base-case deficits under unsupported assumptions; it must be archived as historic learning, not rolled forward as an approved Acceptance 360 forecast.

FEASIBILITY BLOCK	MINIMUM ANALYSIS	OWNER / CHALLENGE
Demand and revenue	Bank-level signed/indicative prices, procurement probability, implementation ramp, renewal and churn.	Commercial lead; Finance independently checks.
Platform costs	Reuse cost, per-bank adapter engineering, certification, licences, support, incident, security, 24/7 and DR.	Technology / Operations, Procurement; Finance challenges.
Two-sided economics	PSS contribution, bank payback and opportunity cost relative to BAU or supplier.	CFO with bank sponsor.
Cash and returns	Monthly ≥36 months; five-year view; NPV, IRR where appropriate, break-even, working capital, financing and taxes.	CFO sign-off.
Adverse scenarios	Zero subsidy/MDR uplift; delayed bank; slower activity; higher FX vendor fees; cyber/compliance costs; partner price pressure.	Risk/CFO independent challenge.
Risk / regulatory	Exact licence, scheme, data, fraud, disputes, resilience, outsourcing and third-party implications.	Legal / CISO / Risk approval.

10.1 The required economic stop line

An initiative should be recommended for stop or radical reduction if no bank with real spending authority validates demand; the cost-to-serve and recurring price do not support an acceptable risk-adjusted return; the operating obligations exceed demonstrable capacity; or the required regulatory and solution-specific permissions cannot be satisfied at a justified cost. Management enthusiasm must not override an unmet mandatory condition.

11 Risks, safeguards and non-negotiable boundaries

RISK	WHY MATERIAL	MANDATORY CONTROL / OWNER
No paying bank	Merchants do not commission bank infrastructure budgets.	V03 economic-buyer and price proof; Commercial/CFO.
National-switch conflict	Duplicating EthSwitch national rails creates weak economics and fragmentation.	Integration rights, scheme participation; Legal/Technology.
Licence/scheme mismatch	Reported new licences do not prove all use cases covered.	Actual grant/conditions; settlement/acquirer/legal matrix.
PSS Pay compliance gap	Card-on-phone needs solution and deployment-specific assessment.	MPoC listing / bank/card scheme obligations; CISO/Legal.
Personal data / cross-bank conflict	Merchant data, privacy, bank competition and segregation.	Data minimisation, lawful basis, tenant separation, audited access [P08].
Failed and uncertain payments	Misleading paid/unpaid status causes losses and disputes.	Event chain, deterministic reconciliation, reversals and exception treatment.
Vendor and related-party cost	Lock-in, outsourcing liability, PSS Trading related-party relationships.	Competitive comparisons, disclosure, contracts and board oversight.
Budget creep	A broad portfolio can absorb capital before finding a buyer.	Hard phase limits, fresh approvals, stop triggers, independent controls.

12 Validation path with separate pre-appointment and institutional work

STAGE	MAY BE PREPARED BEFORE APPOINTMENT	REQUIRES PSS AUTHORISATION
Pre-joining — now	S01 strategic case, S02–S03 desk analysis, V02 public market, V03/V04/V05 instruments, source register and draft finance schema.	No acting as PSS, no formal bank outreach, no confidential system access.
Day 0–30 after mandate	Finalise questions and prioritised options.	Issue internal data requests, scope licences, access agreements, costing approval, baseline PSS Pay/service performance.
Day 31–60	Desk synthesis and revised competitive landscape.	Buyer interviews, merchant fieldwork, partner RFI and actual product/integration tests.
Day 61–90	Draft integrated strategic recommendation.	CFO model, legal/CISO sign-offs, independent challenge and Gate 1 Executive Committee decision.

12.1 Subsequent decision gates

1. Gate 1 — complete feasible commercial option: permit bounded pilot preparation / non-production build or stop, never live processing automatically.
2. Gate 2 — approve live pilot only with bank contract, licence/scheme clearances, tested controls, operational owners and capped exposure.
3. Gate 3 — assess observed merchant and bank economics, resilience, complaints and unit contribution after pilot.
4. Gate 4 — authorise scale as a separate capital decision requiring repeatability across banks and stressed positive economics.

13 Proposed management requests — not official resolutions

REQUEST	LIMIT OF AUTHORITY	DELIVERY / STOP TRIGGER
1 Recognise Acceptance 360 as a research hypothesis and authorise bounded feasibility design.	No rollout, product launch, production deployment, vendor commitment or public company endorsement.	Owner charter, independently priced research ceiling and day-90 recommendation.
2 Permit properly authorised institutional evidence work following appointment.	Bank interviews and internal data only after CEO, Legal and CISO clearance; no informal use of proprietary information.	Current-state audit + buyer proof + regulator/legal scope assessment.
3 Require documented options and investment challenge at Gate 1.	CFO/Risk/Technology/Legal must sign or document dissent; no automatic approval from scores or milestones.	Go / narrow / partner / defer / stop recommendation; formal ExCo vote.

My strategic recommendation: Authorize learning, not deployment. Lead with the narrowest demonstrably bank-funded merchant-operations and connectivity service; compare PSS Pay-led and partner alternatives on actual economics; keep the ability to choose no-build.

14 Conditions precedent and critical research handoffs

UNRESOLVED QUESTION	SOURCE / NEXT DOCUMENT	PROOF STANDARD
Does a bank buyer fund reconciliation and connectivity?	V03 / F04	Economic buyer, documented alternative cost, written pricing/scope and sponsor status.
What already exists in PSS systems?	S03 / V05 / F02	Dated technical demo, contractual rights, verified actual operational logs and cost.
Do merchants value these service outcomes?	V04	Observed task/workflow evidence, not survey enthusiasm alone.
Can the target arrangement be licensed and secured?	F03 / F02	Original regulator/scheme documentation and CISO / Legal review.
Will bank and PSS economics both work?	F04 / F05	Traceable 36-month model, downside and no-build comparison, signed CFO model review.
Is risk-adjusted value better than alternatives?	F01 / F06	Independent documented challenge and ExCo Gate 1 decision.

Annex A Evidence classification and provenance

Document-backed internal references are the existing draft programme materials; they are not PSS-internal data or committee-approved findings. External sources were checked from public web pages as of 19 October 2026. Reported company results are marked as reported; third-party research samples are not automatically representative of all Ethiopian enterprises.

ID	PROVENANCE	USAGE LIMITATION
S02	S02 Business Model and Strategic Options Assessment, 18 Oct 2026.	Preliminary judgement scores; options only.
S03	S03 Current-State Capability and Gap Assessment, 18 Oct 2026.	Public capability map; no systems audit.
V02	V02 Market, Competitor, Ecosystem & Opportunity Assessment, 19 Oct 2026.	Public market research, not a contracted TAM.
V03	V03 Bank Customer Discovery and WTP Protocol, 19 Oct 2026.	No interviews yet.
V04	V04 Merchant Needs, Usage & Concept Validation Protocol, 19 Oct 2026.	No fieldwork yet.
V05	V05 Product Performance Pre-access Framework, 19 Oct 2026.	No internal performance validated.
S04/V01	Master Research, Validation & Feasibility TOR, 18 Oct 2026.	Proposed governance only.
Earlier feasibility	Pre-feasibility assessment and illustrative cash flow, 18 Oct 2026.	Not bankable; old model assumptions not transferred.

Annex B External primary sources and cited public reporting

P01 National Bank of Ethiopia — Draft National Digital Payments Strategy 2026–2030 — official landing page

https://nbe.gov.et/ndps/

Evidence use: Primary regulator; policy remains labelled draft.

P02 National Bank of Ethiopia — Payment Instrument Issuers/System Operators register

https://nbe.gov.et/payment-instrument-issuers-system-operators/

Evidence use: Primary public switch licence listing; not a substitute for newer grant documents.

P03 Shega — Premier Switch Expands Into the Checkout With PoS, Gateway License (30 Aug 2026)

https://www.shega.co/news/premier-switch-expands-into-the-checkout-with-po-s-gateway-license

Evidence use: Public reporting on announcements; seek official copies.

P04 PSS official website — Trading of payment products

https://psseth.com/?page_id=3365

Evidence use: Corporate description; operational scope and supplier rights not independently verified.

P05 EthSwitch official social post — FY2025/26 interoperable transaction figures

https://www.linkedin.com/posts/ethswitch-official_ethswitch-digitalpayments-financialinclusion-activity-7478784976096993282-CEh3

Evidence use: Company-reported totals, different scope to PSS acquiring.

P06 Ethio telecom official — FY2025/26 annual business performance report (23 Jul 2026)

https://www.ethiotelecom.et/2025-26-budget-year-annual-business-performance-report/

Evidence use: Operator-reported registered merchant/agent footprint.

P07 Merchant Payments Observatory / DFS Lab — Ethiopia Wave 1 reports, April 2026

https://mpo.dfslab.net/research.html

Evidence use: Survey population/weighting not equivalent to all MSMEs.

P08 Ethiopian Ministry of Justice — Personal Data Protection Proclamation 1321/2024

https://justice.gov.et/en/law/personal-data-protection-proclamation/

Evidence use: Legislation; application needs legal assessment.

P09 PCI Security Standards Council — Mobile Payments on COTS standard information

https://www.pcisecuritystandards.org/standards/mobile-payments-on-cots-mpoc/

Evidence use: Specific solution and payment-brand requirements must be confirmed.

P10 PSS official website — PCI DSS Level 1 certification announcement (1 Aug 2025)

https://psseth.com/?p=7035

Evidence use: Publicly stated validity ended 8 Jul 2026; current AOC unconfirmed.

P11 PSS official website — Mastercard 3DS/ACS launch (15 Aug 2025)

https://psseth.com/?p=7053

Evidence use: Separate CNP product; merchant acceptance permissions not implied.

Annex C Gate-1 decision-record form (to complete after authorisation)

FIELD	ENTRY REQUIRED AFTER AUTHORISED RESEARCH
Lead bank, named economic buyer and authorisation	NOT YET OBTAINED
Bank problem value / documented alternatives	NOT YET MEASURED
PSS services in scope; operational proof	NOT YET VALIDATED
Licence, PCI, scheme, data and settlement review	NOT YET SIGNED OFF
CFO investment model and downside conclusion	NOT YET COMPLETED
Preferred option / reversed?	PROVISIONAL B; SUBJECT TO DISCONFIRMATION
Independent Risk, Legal, Tech, Finance reviewers	PENDING FORMAL APPOINTMENT
Gate recommendation, budget ceiling, dissent and record	NO DECISION TAKEN

Decision discipline: a written no-build recommendation remains an acceptable output. The appropriate strategic process is one that can detect and stop an unattractive investment before funds or institutional reputation are committed.